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Generative artificial intelligence in assessment: a missing discourse on integrity, originality, and validity

Som Nath Ghimire ^a, Raj K. Baral ^b and Upaj Bhattarai ^c

^aDepartment of English, Tribhuvan University – Mahendra Multiple Campus, Dharan, Nepal; ^bCentral Department of English, Tribhuvan University, Kathmandu, Nepal; ^cSEVIS Compliance Coordinator, University of Houston, Houston, TX, USA

ABSTRACT

The increasing use of generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) technologies by students in assessment practices has drawn considerable attention in higher education (HE). This paper examines how HE students in Nepal perceive and experience GenAI use in assessment practices and how they associate its impacts with academic integrity, originality of student work, and assessment validity. Based on a longitudinal design, this study employed semi-structured interviews to generate the overall study data. Our findings showed that, while Nepali HE students appreciated the wide-ranging capabilities of GenAI, their justification of self-assumed frameworks and denial to acknowledge GenAI use in their work produced more concerning findings. In particular, as these students' conceptions of GenAI emerged, how they subjectively drew ethical frameworks for GenAI use and their false impressions that text prompts and modifications of GenAI's resulting outputs could retain the creative and intellectual values of their work threatened traditional notions of academic integrity and originality. Further, how they overestimated GenAI capabilities for reducing cognitive loads undermined the core visions of HE assessment systems. Our findings contribute to the practical understanding that urgent policy interventions and GenAI literacy programmes are required to motivate thoughtful, responsible, and transparent GenAI use for effective assessment practices in HE.

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GenAI; academic integrity; originality; assessment validity; critical thinking

Background

The ongoing advancement of generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) technologies has presented higher education institutions (HEIs) with unprecedented opportunities and challenges. In particular, following the emergence of OpenAI's ChatGPT in November 2022 and Google AI's Gemini in December 2023, there have been widespread discourses in academia regarding the potentialities and risks of integrating GenAI technologies in pedagogical practices, such as teaching, learning, and research, including assessment, feedback, and student engagement (Tam, 2024). Furthermore, the wrongful use of GenAI technologies by students and their adverse impacts on learning and assessment practices have garnered considerable attention from higher education scholars (Zhang et al., 2024). Studies suggest that students' increasing dependence on and unethical use of GenAI technologies for completing assignments may aggravate assessment challenges, such as assessment security and originality of students' work (Ardito, 2025; Ghimire et al., 2024b; Luo, 2024). It is concerning that, when students use GenAI technologies to produce their work that does not genuinely reflect the standard level of knowledge and competencies that HE envisions, more challenges may stand ahead for HEIs to uphold assessment validity and academic integrity in their systems (Dawson et al., 2024). Nonetheless, scientific evidence on how HE students perceive and experience GenAI in connection with academic integrity, originality of students' work, and assessment validity remains underexplored. Few conceptual studies have discussed that the wrongful adoption of GenAI may exacerbate challenges associated with the validity of assessment practices. However, most of them were focused on HE contexts belonging to the United States and Australia, where many universities have formulated publicly available guidelines on GenAI use in assessment practices (Luo, 2024; Morjaria et al., 2023; Perkins et al., 2024). Further, the available literature from the Global South, where policy and literacy gaps persist, has primarily focused on ethical practices of GenAI in learning and research, with limited attention

to how teachers' and students' self-assumed practices and limited transparency affect the originality of student work and assessment validity (Asamoah & Amarteifio, 2025; Cudjoe & Adebayo, 2025; Hossain et al., 2025). More importantly, in HE contexts of Asian countries like Nepal, where universities largely remain mute about the use of GenAI in assessment, there is a pressing need to understand how students in Nepali universities associate GenAI use with assessment tasks, in terms of academic integrity, originality of student work, and assessment validity. This study addresses the following research questions:

- a. What are Nepali university students' perceptions and experiences of GenAI use vis-à-vis assessment tasks?
- b. How do Nepali university students perceive the impacts of GenAI use in assessment tasks, in terms of academic integrity, originality of student work, and assessment validity?

In doing so, our study advances the global knowledge of how students' evolving perspectives and interactions with GenAI in assessment practices shape their values and attitudes towards academic integrity, originality of student work, and assessment validity within HEIs. In this, our results offer broader insights into what challenges stand ahead for HEIs to sustain the core purposes of assessment and evaluation procedures in the context of GenAI-mediated educational landscape.

Literature review

Assessment and GenAI use in higher education

Assessment as a fundamental part of the HE course cycle is discussed as the evaluation process designed to operate a complex ecosystem of academic standards, support students' learning, and measure their progress in knowledge, skills, and capabilities (Fischer et al., 2024). It is broadly agreed among scholars that assessment demands learners' active engagement in cognitive processing to meet both the learning objectives and assessment targets, ranging from basic information recall to complex analytical, evaluative, and creative capabilities (Toker & Akgun, 2025). Within the HE courses, assessment tasks require students to engage in a range of formative and summative writing activities to support the judgment of their performance, both lower-order and higher-order thinking skills.

Research has shown that the current advancement of AI technologies has been instrumental in simplifying assessment practice by overcoming assessment challenges, most notably linguistic barriers, across disciplines (Dwivedi et al., 2023; Kim et al., 2025). Similarly, it is argued that the integration of GenAI technologies in writing activities can significantly alleviate writer's block and enhance creativity as well as the quality of assessment (Yan, 2023). However, there is a growing concern that HE students may misuse GenAI technologies in writing activities, such as homework, assignments, and research, due to the capability of GenAI to autonomously generate human-like content in various ways, including both textual and visual content (Gonsalves, 2025). This, as a result, might downplay the assessment requirements in HE (Nikolic et al., 2025). Scholars have expressed concerns that the unacceptable usage of AI technologies in assessment may call assessment validity into question in HE (Dawson et al., 2024). Although assessment validity itself remains a troublesome construct in HE, and its critical examination falls outside the scope of this article, we argue that assessment is valid only when students are fairly engaged in assessment practices to meet the standards of HE course cycles through an intended level of performance and achievement (Corbin et al., 2025; Dawson et al., 2024).

Understanding what constitutes fair assessment practices in the context of GenAI is a pressing concern across HEIs. Yet, there is limited evidence regarding how HE students' increasing dependence on GenAI technologies and the normalisation of their misuse as assistance could gradually result in tension with the purpose of assessment systems within HEIs.

Concerns of academic integrity and originality of student work

Academic integrity is conceptualised as fundamental ethical standards or moral values that students, teachers, and members of the academic community should comply with in academic activities. These values require all members of academic communities, including administrators, educators, and learners, to uphold honesty, trust, fairness, respect, responsibility, and courage to sustain integrity in academic activities (International Center for Academic Integrity, 2021). In other words, the violations of these fundamental moral

values in any form of dishonesty, including cheating in assessments, are discussed as threats to academic integrity (Fajt & Schiller, 2025; Ghimire et al., 2024a). Several studies have shown that students' rapid uptake and misuse of GenAI technologies, such as ChatGPT and Gemini, in assessment have imposed significant challenges to academic integrity within HEIs that have intensified the challenges of AI-assisted cheating and plagiarism (Ghimire et al., 2024b; Hutson, 2024). In this respect, research has consistently emphasised the urgent need for HEIs to update their academic integrity policies (Perkins & Roe, 2024). Furthermore, it is feared that students' misuse of GenAI technologies in content generation and the submission of such content as their own original work without proper attribution of sources and inadequate modification undermines established norms around originality, authorship, and academic integrity (Salvagno et al., 2023; Wu et al., 2025).

These studies highlight the concerns about GenAI misuse in assessment practices and its potential negative implications for academic integrity values and the originality of student work. In particular, the above literature suggests that GenAI malpractices by students not only compromise the ethical value of student work but also misreflect the original value of their efforts, thoughts, creativity, and intellectual contributions that HE aims to cultivate through assessment requirements.

Attitudes towards GenAI use in assessment

Many studies have reported students' mixed attitudes towards GenAI use in assessment, suggesting that the findings could broadly compromise the existing understanding of the originality of student work and academic integrity principles. For example, in a survey conducted among students from various disciplines of a university in Hong Kong (Chan, 2024), students were found to have been unsure about subtle misuses of AI tools in academic writing (in terms of generating ideas and modifying AI-generated content, and submitting with acknowledgement of AI use), indicating that they had much confusion about whether their use of AI in assessment potentially enabled academic misconduct. Similarly, a recent study by Corbin et al. (2025) at an Australian university reported teachers and students' confusion regarding what constitutes legitimate and illegitimate uses of GenAI technologies in assessment practices. In their study, both teachers and students considered only copying and pasting GenAI-mediated content in assessments as unethical practices. In another study, Kim et al. (2025) investigated students' perspectives about GenAI use in academic writing after they were involved in ChatGPT4-assisted writing tasks designed by the authors. In the study, students appreciated GenAI as a multitasking writing assistant that helped them generate the initial draft of their writing, which they could further work on, modifying, editing, and adding their thoughts. These students further observed that although the use of GenAI, as an active virtual tutor and peer, enhanced their productivity, performance, and affective domain across various stages of the writing process, they expressed concerns that time constraints and over-reliance on GenAI had negative impacts on higher-order thinking skills and deep learning abilities.

Together, these studies illustrate the diversity of educators' and students' perspectives and experiences of using GenAI in assessment, along with unfolding challenges that may stand ahead for HEIs to ensure the principles of academic integrity, originality of student work, and assessment validity. Nonetheless, a consolidated body of knowledge is lacking in the literature regarding how these tripartite dynamics of assessment ecosystems interact with one another in the context of GenAI. Therefore, this study addresses the aforementioned gap through a critical examination of Nepali HE students' evolving perspectives, experiences, and perceived impacts of GenAI in assessment practices.

Methodology

Research context

Nepal is home to 17 universities, both central and provincial, and seven autonomous medical academies, all of which are offering degree programmes from the undergraduate to doctoral levels. A total of 1,432 HEIs fall under these universities and academies, and they have enrolled 633,053 students in the academic year 2023–2024 (UGC, 2024). Notably, Tribhuvan University (TU), the oldest of all, alone accounts for 491,299 students, representing 77.61% of total enrolment, and plays a significant role in shaping the academic and

assessment landscape of the country (UGC, 2024, p. 1). These HEIs operate under annual, semester, and trimester systems, with considerable variation in assessment policies across universities and disciplines.

Assessment practices in Nepali HEIs are largely reliant on conventional formats: paper-based sit-in examinations conducted under centralised monitoring. Most universities run final examinations through designated exam centres, while internal evaluations (project work, presentations, quizzes, term papers, concept notes, reviews, research papers) are left to the discretion of departments or instructors. During the COVID-19 pandemic, however, these practices faced unprecedented disruption (Baral et al., 2024). While some universities suspended examinations, others adopted alternative methods such as online exams or home-centre assessments. These temporary arrangements exposed systemic gaps that include inconsistent technological infrastructure, underdeveloped digital assessment strategies, and a lack of preparedness among faculty (Baral & Ghimire, 2025; Thapaliya et al., 2023). These structural shortcomings are further compounded by institutional weaknesses in upholding academic integrity. In a recent policy analysis, Dahal and Eaton (2025) revealed that although the UGC and 10 universities have established some integrity-related provisions, only a few have formal integrity policies in place. Even where such policies exist, the emphasis tends to fall on punitive responses rather than on cultivating a culture of ethical academic practice.

The need to revisit assessment practices is further highlighted by persistent quality concerns. Baral (2021) identified centralised governance, outdated curricula, and limited pedagogical training as structural barriers that hinder academic credibility. A pass rate of only 30.1% at Tribhuvan University and 30% at Nepal Sanskrit University (UGC, 2024, p. 2) indicates not only academic underperformance but also possible misalignments in curriculum, instruction, and evaluation.

Although, prior to our 2023–2024 interviews, universities did not have comprehensive or clearly articulated policies on the responsible use of AI tools, one limited provision existed at Tribhuvan University. The Secretariat of the TU Senate and Executive Council (2023), in its regulation, stated that any AI-generated content detected by plagiarism-checking software shall not be accepted in dissertations, theses, articles, or reports (Section 10.3). Most recently, the Government of Nepal (2025) introduced an AI policy that imagines the establishment of an AI Excellence Center to enable universities, academic and research bodies, and educational institutions to conduct studies, research, and national-level initiatives related to AI, yet it remains largely silent on responsible AI use.

Against this backdrop, the emergence of GenAI tools, as suggested above, has introduced new opportunities and challenges for assessment integrity, originality, and validity. As Nepali HEIs begin grappling with the implications of GenAI, a better understanding of existing assessment cultures becomes imperative for designing future-ready, ethically grounded evaluation frameworks.

Materials and procedures

In this study, we generated overall study data by conducting longitudinal interviews (in three phases) with 10 undergraduate and 10 graduate students from three Nepali universities. This approach was chosen to broadly capture the evolving nature of HE students' attitudes toward and interactions with GenAI, as well as their concerns associated with academic integrity, originality, and validity of assessment practices. We recruited participants through a purposive sampling approach to gather diverse perspectives on the use of GenAI in assessment. To involve participants in this study, we obtained informed consent from all participants to conduct semi-structured interviews with them over three semesters of their academic courses. Before commencing the interviews, we briefly explained the purpose and the nature of our study, along with research questions, to all the participants individually. To answer our research questions, our longitudinal interview guidelines involved several open-ended questions to draw the required dataset for this study. For this purpose, Galletta's (2013) ideas provided the guidelines to design primary questions, sub-questions, and probes to generate in-depth discussions on this study's key concerns – academic integrity, originality of student work, and assessment validity.

In the first phase, we asked the students, "How have you utilised GenAI in writing activities?" and followed up with questions regarding potential opportunities and risks of GenAI technologies in HEIs to gauge immediate user responses. In the second phase, the students were asked, "How have the ways compared to the first phase how you utilised GenAI in writing changed over the time" and follow-up questions if they had any concerns in terms of acceptable and unacceptable use of GenAI technologies. Finally, in the

third phase, we asked them, “How do you think the use of GenAI throughout these three semester courses has shaped the knowledge, skills, creativity, and capacity that you have been supposed to master/acquire?” and other follow-up questions regarding the impacts of GenAI use on assessment practices. Using phone calls or video conferencing tools, such as Zoom, Google Meet, and Facebook Messenger, all the interviews were conducted individually in Nepali between July 2023 to December 2024. Each interview lasted between half an hour to one hour. These interviews were audio-recorded on laptops or mobile phones, translated, and transcribed into English by capturing a verbatim account based on word-for-word as well as free translation methods to ensure cultural appropriateness. We repeatedly listened to the audio recordings and collaboratively resolved our disagreements on word choices to ensure participants’ intended meaning as well as the accuracy and reliability of translation. Then, strictly following the guidelines recommended by Braun and Clarke (2006) for inductive thematic analysis, the data were systematically coded, collated, categorised under potential themes, analysed, and interpreted along with compelling extracts in the report. Throughout the coding procedures, we reread the transcribed verbatim multiple times, had regular meetings, and resolved our disagreements on codes by collaboratively reinterpreting and redefining codes until we reached consensus. This allowed us to both enhance coding reliability and identify the centrality of themes in our report. To ensure the confidentiality and anonymity of participants, as suggested by Cohen et al. (2017), the real names of all the participants and their educational institutions have been anonymized as shown in Table 1.

Results

Students’ experiences of and attitudes toward GenAI technologies in assessment

In this study, we found that students have varying experiences and attitudes towards the integration of GenAI technologies in assessment. In the first phase, almost all students attributed their use of GenAI to an emerging societal trend driven by curiosity and excitement. In this, many students admitted using these tools as a virtual assistant to experiment with, generate basic information and ideas (S3, S4), paraphrase them to resolve writer’s block (S1), write content (S3), and frame assignments in a manageable way to accomplish their project work, presentation, term papers, concept notes, and research writing (S7, S10). During the second phase, most of these students reported that GenAI technologies gradually functioned as saviours (S6, S7, S18), which they variously identified as feedback generators (S8, S16), task expeditors (S2, S12), efficient summarisers (S1), and intimate writing partners (S5) that could help them break down complex ideas, refine their understanding, and expedite research activities. For example:

As part of our assignments, we are required to write literature reviews and reflection notes on research papers every week. You know that tools like ChatGPT allow us to upload our files, books, and articles, and instantly summarize whatever we want. What’s more, they even help us organize, refine, and proofread our writings. They are the real saviours in times of need, for students like us who are hugely occupied with jobs and need to accomplish multiple tasks. (S11, Interview II)

In the above excerpt, S11, who represented the voice of the majority of students, highlighted the time and effort-saving capabilities of GenAI tools to reduce cognitive loads required for reading and writing tasks, most notably through summarisation, feedback, and content writing facilities. This, many students indicated, eventually expedited assessment tasks.

Further, in the third phase, while the majority of students’ GenAI use in assessment activities mostly remained the same as in the second phase, many students, particularly those at the Master’s and MPhil levels, identified GenAI tools as task enhancers (S1, S11) not only to synthesise complex ideas but also organise and enhance random thoughts and research data input to accomplish their assessment tasks in an advanced manner. Nonetheless, in the third phase, it was interesting to note that all the students reported

Table 1. Participants’ profile.

Universities	Symbol and level of study
Uni 1	S1(MPhil.), S2(BCA), S3(BCA), S5(BSC), S6(BSC), S9(BSC), S10(BSC), S14(BCA), S16(MA), S17(BCA), S18(MPhil.), S20(BCA)
Uni 2	S4(BBA), S7(BBA), S8(MBA), S19(BA-LLB)
Uni 3	S11(MPhil.), S12(MPhil.), S13(MPhil.), S15(MPhil.)

their increased concerns and awareness about GenAI hallucinations. Their voices pointed to the feelings of uncertainty regarding how well and critically they could handle these risks in assessment practices. For example:

You know, they can even produce made-up details, though convincing. Once, I got into a serious problem due to fake references it generated for my paper [...]. That's the reason why I always cross-check responses with other GenAI tools or credible sources if I can locate and modify the content significantly in my own words. (S1, Interview III)

Ambiguous attitudes towards GenAI (mis)use and its impacts on academic integrity and originality

Across all phases of the interviews, we found students' ambiguous attitudes towards what counts as acceptable GenAI use and whether their GenAI use compromised the values of academic integrity and the originality of their work. In other words, the students expressed uncertainty about the misuse of GenAI in assessment activities. In particular, although all the students throughout the study agreed that the blatant copying and pasting of AI-generated content and submitting such writing tasks without modification could be unethical, they were largely unaware of the subtle misuse of GenAI tools in assessments.

In the first phase, many students described that it was acceptable to use GenAI for brainstorming, paraphrasing, summarising, and writing initial content to clear writer's block, and start their project. In this phase, students, particularly belonging to Master's and MPhil levels, thought that GenAI use was acceptable to the extent that GenAI-mediated content could pass through plagiarism detection tools. In the second and third phase, they explained that the use of GenAI in assessment gradually shifted from personal habit to normalised practice among their peers for completing the entire assessment, highlighting its use as fair so long as they could rewrite or modify the content written by GenAI technologies, either based on their prompts or GenAI feedback. Surprisingly, both in the second and the third phase, the majority of students belonging to Bachelor's levels established their line of reasoning that rewriting the content first and then using other GenAI humaniser tools for multiple modifications should not be regarded as threats to academic misconduct. When asked about why these students did not prefer to acknowledge the use of GenAI in assessment, they, interestingly, attributed the confusion either to the dearth of GenAI policies at their universities (S1, S9, S17, S20), a lack of proper guidance from their professors (S4, S6, S10, S12), or reasoning that GenAI-mediated content were based on their original prompts (S1, S2, S8, S11, S12, S13, S15, S16, S18, S19, S20). For example:

I always use my ideas to modify the content [...] either by rewriting it in my new sentence structure or summarizing it in my own words, and then asking GenAI tools to proofread and polish the content before submission. Why should I acknowledge GenAI when I use my data, apply my critical insights, become heavily engaged in my work, and do significant work on my own? (S2, Interview II).

It is much clearer that such voices further raised an important tension about the lack of AI literacy regarding how they utilised GenAI technologies to compromise honesty and fairness in assessment processes seemed to be heavily rationalised upon what they assumed as acceptable usage of GenAI.

Additionally, in the first phase, when we asked these students about how GenAI could impact the originality of their work, they expressed their concerns that over-reliance on GenAI could deteriorate creativity, personal thoughts, and intellectual contribution in assessment tasks. However, in the second phase, students of Master's and MPhil levels associated the originality of their assessment tasks with technical compliance, whether their writing could pass the plagiarism detection tools. Secondly, they highlighted the original values of their assessment with how critically and creatively they could modify the GenAI-mediated content. But for the majority of Bachelor's level students, originality was mostly a matter of modification through the use of other GenAI humaniser tools and alteration of words, syntax, and sentence structures. Nonetheless, in both cases, all the students associated the originality of their work with the series of prompts (from sketches to final production), from identifying research gaps, framing research questions, and generating literature themes, to revising their work. It indicates that students initially assumed their creativity and intellectual contribution remained intact as long as they engineered the prompts and made edits to the AI-produced text. However, this assumption was questioned in the third phase by some of the Master's and MPhil students, who recognised a tension between their personal voices and

GenAI's resulting output. Some of them reported a sense of voice loss and reduced agency. For instance, S12 shared:

[...] Nonetheless, over time, I have become more confused about whether the logics I go for are really my own! The machine has really affected the way I take my positions, give prompts, and modify the content. I find myself lost in what these machines generate. (**Interview III**)

These reflections suggest a growing awareness that originality is not limited to producing texts but extends to sustaining one's creative presence and intellectual identity throughout the writing process.

Blurred lines between relieving affective burdens or eroding assessment validity?

In all phases of interviews, the majority of students repeatedly highlighted that the use of GenAI technologies in assessment practices helped considerably relieve mental burdens required to handle their work, from deeply engaging in reading tasks (S5, S13, S19), drafting their writings (S9, S14, S15), and seeking feedback from professors (S1, S11 S13), to revising and finalising their work (S6, S8, S17). This, these students further suggested, helped them cope with reading and writing anxieties and improve learning outcomes in terms of grades. S17 shared:

You might know well how hard it is to carry out multiple reading and writing projects every week. Lots of worries, right? Particularly for students like me who can't easily cope with coding and debugging issues that are too complex to understand and handle in writing. Showing one's report to professors and gaining criticism on that would frustrate anyone further. These tools are real guiding lights. (**Interview II**)

The above interview excerpt suggested that GenAI technologies could be instrumental in overcoming reading and writing stress that students experience owing to either linguistic, technical, conceptual, or cognitive limitations to fulfil course requirements. Nonetheless, when asked about how confident they were about meeting intended learning outcomes, in terms of mastering the skills and abilities envisioned by their courses, these students expressed their uncertainty and confusion. In particular, their voices indicated that the over-reliance on GenAI for summarisation of reading materials, content writing, and modification purposes gradually harmed their critical and analytical abilities. For instance:

Initially, using ChatGPT to summarize reading materials that are mostly beyond my level felt like getting rid of my burden [...] Now, I am in my final semester and working on my thesis, and I feel like I have lost my patience and criticality. I sometimes really worry about how I can handle piles of books, research papers, and study data on my own. (**S15, Interview III**)

It is much clearer that the given expression pointed out how over-reliance on GenAI could disengage students with authentic materials, leading to a reduced sense of self-efficacy and confidence in handling assessments that require critical reading and reasoning abilities. S16 added:

It is true that if students like us keep skipping the critical thinking and manual effort involved in reading, writing, or research, we are bound to miss out on valuable learning and writing experiences. (**Interview III**)

In many respects, these examples illustrate the fact that the use of GenAI, on the one hand, can provide a false sense of reduced cognitive loads that students often experience for the time being. On the other hand, the tendency to avoid reading culture gradually can erode one's ability to comprehend authentic materials that are foundational to a deep understanding of disciplinary knowledge and criticality in assessment practices.

Discussion and conclusions

This study aimed to investigate university students' perceptions and experiences of GenAI use in assessment practices, with a major focus on tripartite concerns of academic integrity, originality of student work, and assessment validity. While these concerns are not new and have gained increasing traction in global scholarship, albeit in isolation (He et al., 2025) or conceptual (Dawson et al., 2024; Luo, 2024), this study's contribution lies in the single body of empirical insights on how they interact with each other and impact the complex ecosystem of assessment practices in HE systems.

Our findings showed that HE students in Nepal had evolving experiences and perceptions of GenAI use in assessment. While these students initially linked GenAI tools with their curiosity and excitement, they

gradually identified these technologies as brainstorming and paraphrasing tools to head start their project work, concept notes, term papers, and research writing. Students' reported information in the second and third phases indicated GenAI tools functioned as efficient saviours that helped them break down complex ideas, refine their understanding, and expedite research activities. In particular, these students recognised GenAI technologies as an integral part of assessment processes, from brainstorming assessment ideas, identifying research gaps, generating research questions, writing literature reviews and findings, to proof-reading and finalising the assessment. These findings, to a great extent, are consistent with prior studies that highlight the time and effort-saving capabilities of GenAI in education, in terms of overcoming the assessment challenges, including writer's block and linguistic barriers (Ghimire et al., 2024b; Kim et al., 2025). However, these students' gradual awareness of GenAI hallucinations and the importance they highlighted for cross-checking AI-generated content indicated these students' concerns regarding evolving threats that GenAI potentially could impose on education. Nonetheless, the temptation to over-rely on GenAI for cross-validation, summarisation of reading materials, feedback generation, and modification of assessment content pointed to these students' perceived benefits of GenAI or a sense of lack of viable alternatives.

One concerning finding is that although the majority of students in this study accepted that they heavily relied on GenAI tools to write and modify content, many of them expressed confusion about whether the processes involved in the modification of the content compromised academic integrity. These students viewed only copying and pasting AI-generated content as a violation of academic integrity. While these findings are to some extent consistent with prior literature (Corbin et al., 2025; Fajt & Schiller, 2025; Kim et al., 2025), the confusion regarding what is acceptable and unacceptable use of GenAI in assessment remains a pressing concern, as Hutson (2024) highlighted. It is worth noting that these students justified that they used their ideas and prompts to retain the originality of their work and denied the proper acknowledgment of GenAI use in assessments. Interestingly, these students attributed their failures to maintain transparency to the dearth of policy and the lack of proper guidance from their professors, which probably imposed barriers to the transparent usage of GenAI in assessment processes. This suggests that when individuals devalue one's intellectual contribution and independent efforts (Luo, 2024), they naturally tend to normalise unethical behaviours, fall victim to academic malpractices, and downplay the values of academic integrity, including responsibility, transparency, and accountability in research writing (Tili et al., 2025). Further, what is more concerning is that our participants had drawn their self-assumed framework to justify the unacknowledged use of GenAI as acceptable. In this sense, our findings have serious implications regarding how students' self-assumed framework for acceptable GenAI use violates the traditional notion of academic integrity and the originality of student work, thereby pointing to adverse risks to the effectiveness and purpose of assessment practices in HE. Therefore, given the centrality of fairness, accountability, and the value of independent intellectual effort in assessment practices within education, it is paramount that HE institutions in Nepal carefully devise regulatory frameworks that motivate students to engage in the thoughtful practice of GenAI technologies.

Further, findings from this study suggested that GenAI provided personalised interactive support for learning engagement for HE students, tailoring to the specific needs of these students to effectively handle the perceived complexity of authentic materials and research papers, as part of the assessment requirement. Surprisingly, these students later described how they avoided a deeper approach to reading that resulted in a false concept of increasing confidence in their ability to handle multiple assessment tasks for the time being. But, in the long run, they gradually realised how over-reliance on GenAI for a swift understanding of course materials and research papers resulted in superficial cognitive processing, deteriorating their critical reading and thinking abilities. Contrary to findings of prior studies (Pan et al., 2025), these students' over-reliance on GenAI for the summarisation of authentic materials to expedite their learning and research tasks appears to have adversely impacted the expected learning outcomes, skills, and capabilities envisioned by their university courses (Corbin & Walton, 2025). It should be acknowledged that assessment practices, both reading and writing, in higher education have a unique purpose to foster deep learning engagement, creativity, criticality, and reasoning among students. In light of these findings, we contend that if students are unaware of and devalue the functionality of authentic readings (Baron & Mangan, 2021) and independent intellectual contributions in assessment practices to garner unfair advantage, HE will soon be presented with unforeseen challenges to retain the effectiveness and purposes of assessments.

In many ways, Nepali HE students' evolving views and experiences of GenAI in assessment practices, nonetheless, indicated a clear tension between ethical reasoning and growing awareness of GenAI misuse. These students rationalised ethical usage of GenAI and originality of their work in relation to subjective judgements and text prompts. Interestingly, they accepted over-dependence on GenAI for assessment completion led to a reduced sense of personal voices and agency among Master's and MPhil students, which pointed to their implicit awareness of GenAI misuse and its undesired consequences on intellectual capabilities, including creative abilities, critical reasoning, and higher-order thinking skills.

In sum, our findings have greater significance in terms of informing HEIs about the unfolding prospects and challenges that GenAI poses to university course cycles, most notably across assessment systems. Further, our analysis suggests that, insofar as the unclear boundaries between what is ethical and unethical practices of GenAI are based on subjective judgment, it is almost impossible to determine the extent to which students' prompts, GenAI-mediated outputs, and modifications reflect originality of student work to meet the core purpose of the entire HE assessment systems. In light of our findings, we argue that stakeholders across HE systems have a greater responsibility to recognise the urgency of policy interventions and educators to support GenAI literacy programmes. In this, we encourage HEIs to set a minimum standard in assessment policies to motivate students' responsible, accountable, and transparent usage and disclosure of GenAI assistance in their work, and teachers to critically evaluate student work that prioritises authentic learning and writing efforts and sustains the effectiveness of assessment practices within HE systems.

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Notes on contributors

Som Nath Ghimire is an Assistant Professor of English at Tribhuvan University, Nepal. His areas of research interest include media, surveillance, criminology, discourse studies, gender studies, academic integrity, higher education, technology in education, social justice, and rhetoric and communication.

Raj K. Baral, PhD, is an Assistant Professor of English at Tribhuvan University, Kathmandu, Nepal. His research interests span from literature, language, cultural studies, and higher education/policy. He has been published in *Higher Education Research & Development*, *Distance Education*, *Cogent Arts and Humanities*, *Journal of Academic Ethics*, among others.

Upaj Bhattarai is an international education professional specialising in SEVIS compliance and student advising, currently serving as a SEVIS Compliance Coordinator at the University of Houston. He advises international students and scholars on visa regulations and cultural integration. He holds a Master's in International Relations from the University of Northampton, UK, and an MA in English from Tribhuvan University, Nepal. A former J-1 scholar through a U.S. Department of State programme, he is deeply committed to global education and cross-cultural exchange.

Data availability statement

The data that support the findings of this study are not publicly available due to their containing information that could compromise the privacy of research participants.

ORCID

Som Nath Ghimire  <http://orcid.org/0000-0003-2831-0847>

Raj K. Baral  <http://orcid.org/0000-0003-2279-3526>

Upaj Bhattarai  <http://orcid.org/0000-0002-1525-7111>

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